the forwards coach for both the Bulls and the Springboks.

In fact, it was more than a decent team; it was an exceptional team.

The Affies A field was our home ground, bordered by the grandstand where the entire school stood shoulder to shoulder, another grandstand for the Club 600 for old boys and parents, and the Frank le Roux boarding house, where I stayed for a few years and where we spent many happy evenings socialising in the most sought-after room overlooking the rugby field, the room allocated in 2001 to Wynand Olivier, the centre who later played for the Bulls and the Boks.

We wanted the A field to be a genuine fortress and we started the season with emphatic victories over Wynberg Boys' High School and Pietersburg, as well as a couple of hard-fought wins over tough opponents such as HTS Middelburg and Paarl Gimnasium. In fact, we had managed to win 12 out of 12 by the time we prepared to play Grey College, Bloemfontein, traditionally one of our greatest rivals, at home on Saturday, 25 May 2002.

The day dawned bright and sunny, and the sense of excitement was extraordinary.

Grey Bloem and Affies were widely recognised as the two outstanding school teams in the country at the time and, with three draws between the teams in the previous five seasons, most people were suggesting that the winner of this particular match would earn the right to call themselves the No. 1 school side in South Africa.

The stakes were high, and my parents decided to drive from Warmbaths to Pretoria to watch the game – in fact, they would not miss an Affies match all season – and were having a late breakfast nearby when they saw Hansie Cronjé, the former South African cricket captain, eating at the same restaurant.

As an enthusiastic Old Grey himself, Hansie had travelled to watch the big match and would have felt reasonably optimistic about the outcome. The visiting team included promising young players such as hooker Bismarck du Plessis and scrumhalf Ruan Pienaar, both destined